East India Company's Bengal Army was in open revolt and, in many cases, the British officers had all been killed. The phenomenon spread like wildfire across large parts of North and Central India. Note that the revolt did not have a centralized leadership but occurred in a number of different centres and had a number of different leaders, usually dispossessed members of the old Indian aristocracy. Delhi was one of the important centres of the uprising.

By 1857, the glory days of Shahjahanabad were a fading memory. The eighty-two-year-old Bahadur Shah Zafar was an emperor in name alone and his writ barely ran in Delhi. The royal family lived off a pension provided by the British and many of the junior branches of the family had been reduced to extreme poverty. William Sleeman, an official who visited the Red Fort a few years before the revolt, tells us of how 1200 members of the family lived in the palace off the meagre pension but were too proud to work. [8] Instead, there are amusing stories of how some of these princes would try to use their family name to swindle money. Even the palace inside the Red Fort was in a state of severe disrepair. In 1824, Bishop Herber described the palace gardens as 'dirty, lonely and wretched; the bath and fountain dry; the inlaid pavement hid with lumber and gardener's sweepings, and the walls stained with the dung of birds and bats.' [9] Things would have been worse by the 1850s.

There has been a tendency in recent years by writers like William Dalrymple to present the court of Bahadur Shah Zafar as a 'court of great brilliance' that was in the 'middle of remarkable cultural flowering' and the 'greatest literary renaissance in modern Indian history'. [10] This is inaccurate. While it is true that the court did include some excellent poets like Ghalib and Zauq, by the 1850s Delhi would have felt distinctly provincial and archaic compared to Calcutta. A 'renaissance' is about new ideas, innovation and vigour. Ghalib's poetry may be very good from a literary perspective but it is mostly a lament for a world that was collapsing around him. It contains no vision of the future.